score high for corruption and have fewer press freedoms and higher numbers of journalist deaths… In the last six years, 15 journalists working on corruption stories in these countries were murdered, as reported by the Committee to Protect Journalists (CPJ).'

Transparency International's Managing Director, Patricia Moreira, said, 'No activist or reporter should have to fear for their lives when speaking out against corruption. Given current crackdowns on both civil society and the media worldwide, we need to do more to protect those who speak up.' The CPI report stated, 'Further analysis of the results indicates that countries with the least protection for press and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) also tend to have the worst rates of corruption.'

Worse still, the report named India as the most corrupt country in the Asia-Pacific region, with 69 per cent bribery rates, which means that almost seven out of ten people had to pay a bribe to access public services. Vietnam was the second-most corrupt country with 65 per cent bribery rates, whereas Pakistan with only 40 per cent bribery rates, ranked much better than India. Japan came out as the least corrupt nation, with a 0.2 per cent bribery rate.

This demolishes one of the main arguments presented in favour of demonetization. The Economic Survey for 2016–2017 had stated, 'Across the globe there is a link between cash and nefarious activities: the higher the amount of cash in circulation, the greater the amount of corruption... In this sense, attempts to reduce the cash in an economy could have important long-term benefits in terms of reducing levels of corruption.'

As it happens, data does not support this argument. Japan is a case in point. Japan's Currency to GDP ratio in 2015 was 18.61 per cent, much higher than India's at 12.51 per cent. In the same year (2015), Japan was ranked as the 18th least corrupt nation in the world while India was ranked 76th, i.e., Japan, which has a much higher currency to GDP ratio than India, has far less corruption.